

AN ILLUSTRATED HISTORY

EGYPT

Five Thousand Years on the Nile

A short illustrated history, from the first flood to the Grand Egyptian Museum

EGYPT

Five Thousand Years on the Nile

A short illustrated history, from the first flood to the Grand Egyptian
Museum

Text compiled 2026. Photographs are reproduced from Wikimedia Commons under public domain, CC0, CC BY or CC BY-SA terms; each is credited on the final page.

CONTENTS

I. THE ANCIENT KINGDOM

c. 5000 BC – AD 394

The Gift of the River	c. 5000 – 3100 BC	5
Two Lands, One Crown	c. 3100 BC	6
The First Pyramid	c. 2670 BC	7
The Great Pyramid	c. 2560 BC	8
The Woman Who Was King	c. 1479 – 1458 BC	9
The Heretic and the Queen	c. 1353 – 1336 BC	10
The Boy King	c. 1332 – 1323 BC	11
The Builder and the Battle	c. 1279 – 1213 BC	12
The Last Pharaoh	51 – 30 BC	13
Words of the God	the written record	14

II. THE MODERN NATION

1805 – 2025

The Pasha Who Made a State	1805 – 1848	16
A Ditch Between Two Seas	1869	17
Wonderful Things	1922	18
The Officers	1952 – 1954	19
Nasser	1956 – 1970	20
The Dam	1960 – 1970	21
The Crossing	6 October 1973	22
The Handshake	1977 – 1981	23
Eighteen Days	2011	24
The House of the Pharaohs	2025	25



I

THE ANCIENT KINGDOM

c. 5000 BC – AD 394

Three thousand years of pharaohs is a longer stretch of time than separates Cleopatra from us. What follows are ten moments from it.



A felucca on the Nile at Kom Ombo. The current runs north, the prevailing wind blows south: the river carried traffic both ways long before there were roads.

The Gift of the River

Egypt is a thread of green drawn through a desert the size of a continent — and every inch of it was laid down by one river.

Herodotus called Egypt the gift of the river, and for once the tourist's cliché is literally true. Rain almost never falls on the Nile valley. What made the valley farmable was the flood: each summer, monsoon rain on the Ethiopian highlands sent the Blue Nile down in a surge that spread across the floodplain and left behind a layer of black silt.

Egyptians named their country after that silt — Kemet, the black land — and set it against Deshret, the red land of desert on either side. The distinction was not poetic. Beyond the reach of the flood, nothing grew; within it, one of the most reliable harvests in the ancient world came up year after year.

Farming villages appear along the valley and in the

Fayum from around 5000 BC, and by the Naqada period their potters, coppersmiths and boatbuilders were trading the length of the river. The Nile was a highway with a rare property: its current flows north while the prevailing wind blows south, so a boat could drift down and sail back up. A single valley could be governed as one place.

It could also be measured. Nilometers cut into the rock at Elephantine let officials read the height of the coming flood and set the year's taxes against it. Too low meant famine; too high meant washed-out villages. Out of that arithmetic — surplus grain, a calendar of three seasons, scribes to record both — grew the machinery of a state.

6,650 km

LENGTH OF THE NILE

3%

OF EGYPT THAT IS FARMLAND

3 seasons

FLOOD, GROWTH, HARVEST



The Narmer Palette, found at Hierakonpolis in 1898: the king in the white crown of Upper Egypt raises his mace over a kneeling captive — the oldest royal image we can read.

Two Lands, One Crown

The first thing Egypt recorded about itself was a conquest, carved on a slab used for grinding eye paint.

On one face of a shield-shaped stone palette a king in the tall white crown of the south raises a mace over a kneeling captive. Turn it over and the same king, now in the flat red crown of the northern Delta, walks in procession past rows of beheaded enemies. Small signs beside his head spell out a name: Narmer.

Egyptologists once read the palette as a snapshot of the day Upper and Lower Egypt became one country. The truth is slower and more interesting. Unification looks to have taken generations of pressure from the southern towns — Hierakonpolis, Naqada, Abydos — before a single dynasty

held the whole valley. What the palette records is not the event but the idea: one man, two crowns, a country defined by the joining of its halves.

That idea outlived every dynasty that used it. For the next three millennia the pharaoh was Lord of the Two Lands, and coronation meant putting on both crowns. A new capital, Memphis, was planted at the hinge between them where the valley opens into the Delta.

The palette also carries some of the earliest hieroglyphs — writing that begins, as it so often does, in the service of accounting and royal propaganda rather than literature.

64 cm

HEIGHT OF THE PALETTE

c. 3200 BC

FIRST HIEROGLYPHS

30

DYNASTIES TO COME



The Step Pyramid of Djoser at Saqqara, the oldest large stone building in the world, restored and reopened to visitors in 2020.

The First Pyramid

Before Djoser, kings were buried under flat mud-brick benches. His architect stacked six of them in stone and invented monumental architecture.

The Step Pyramid began as a mastaba — the low rectangular tomb standard for the first two dynasties — and then kept growing. Six diminishing stages went up over the original block until the structure stood some 62 metres above the Saqqara plateau, visible from the capital at Memphis.

Its architect is the first in history whose name survives: Imhotep, also Djoser's vizier and high priest. Two thousand years later Egyptians were worshipping him as a god of healing, and the Greeks identified him with Asclepius — an unusual career for a civil servant.

What made the leap possible was a change of material. Imhotep's masons cut limestone into small blocks about the size of the mud bricks they replaced, so existing building habits still worked. Around the pyramid they laid out a walled enclosure of some fifteen hectares filled with dummy buildings: shrines with no interiors, doors carved permanently open, a stone stage-set where the dead king could run his jubilee festival forever.

Everything that follows at Meidum, Dahshur and Giza is an argument with this building — how to make the steps smooth, how to make it bigger, how to make it last.

62 m

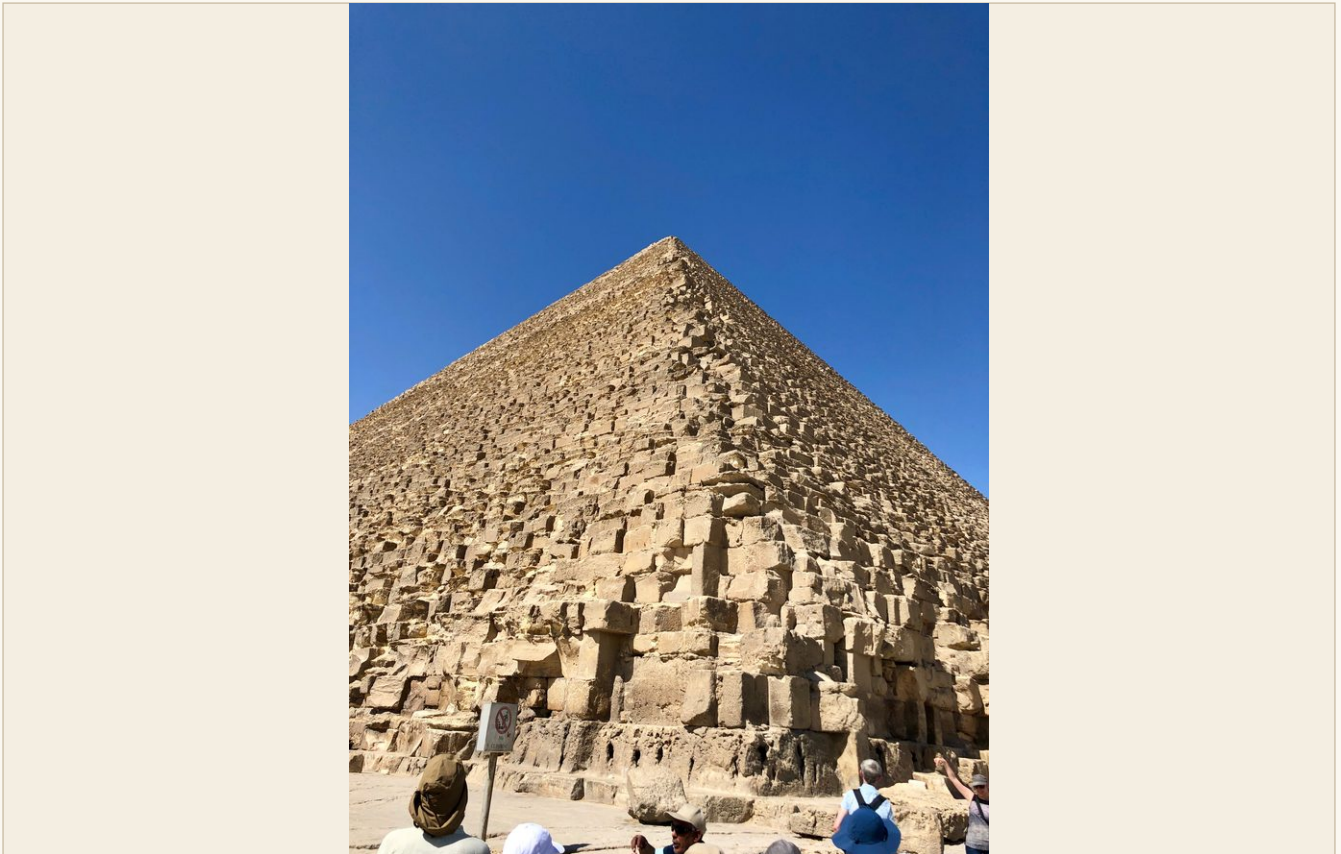
ORIGINAL HEIGHT

15 ha

WALLED ENCLOSURE

Imhotep

FIRST NAMED ARCHITECT



The pyramid of Khufu at Giza. It was the tallest structure built by humans for roughly 3,800 years.

The Great Pyramid

Two and a half million blocks, laid to a tolerance modern surveyors respect — and we finally know who moved them, because one of the foremen kept a diary.

Khufu's pyramid rose 146.6 metres, covered thirteen acres, and was set out with its sides aligned to true north within a fifteenth of a degree. The base is level to a few centimetres across more than five hectares. Whatever else the Fourth Dynasty had, it had surveying.

For centuries the labour behind it was imagined as mass slavery, an image owed more to Hollywood and the Book of Exodus than to evidence. Excavation of the workers' town south of the plateau found bakeries, breweries, cattle bones and a cemetery of workers buried with care near the king they built for — the profile of a paid, rotating

workforce, not a chain gang.

In 2013 the argument was settled by paperwork. At Wadi al-Jarf on the Red Sea, archaeologists found the oldest inscribed papyri yet known, including the logbook of an inspector named Merer. It records his crew ferrying fine limestone from the Tura quarries to Giza, trip by trip, in the twenty-seventh year of Khufu's reign.

The king himself is nearly invisible. The only certain likeness of the man who built the largest tomb on earth is an ivory figurine three inches high.

146.6 m

ORIGINAL HEIGHT

2.3 million

BLOCKS OF STONE

7.5 cm

HIS ONLY CERTAIN PORTRAIT



The terraced mortuary temple of Hatshepsut at Deir el-Bahari, cut into the cliffs opposite Luxor.

The Woman Who Was King

She began as regent for a stepson too young to rule, and ended with the full titulary of a pharaoh — beard included.

Hatshepsut took power as regent for the child Thutmose III and within a few years had assumed the complete royal titulary. Egyptian art had no vocabulary for a female king, so her sculptors used the existing one: she appears in the kilt, the headcloth and the ceremonial false beard, while the inscriptions beside her keep the feminine endings.

Her reign is notable for what it did not do. There is little campaigning; instead there is trade. The temple walls at Deir el-Bahari carry a detailed record of a naval expedition to Punt, on the Red Sea coast, returning with ebony, ivory, gold, myrrh and living incense trees with their root-balls wrapped for the voyage — an early picture of a supply

chain.

The temple itself, laid out by her steward Senenmut against the cliffs at Deir el-Bahari, is the most modern-looking building to survive from the ancient world: three colonnaded terraces answering the horizontal strata of the rock behind them.

Late in Thutmose III's own reign her images were chiselled out and her name left off the king lists. The erasure came decades after her death, which argues for dynastic housekeeping — securing his own line of succession — rather than a grudge.

~22 years

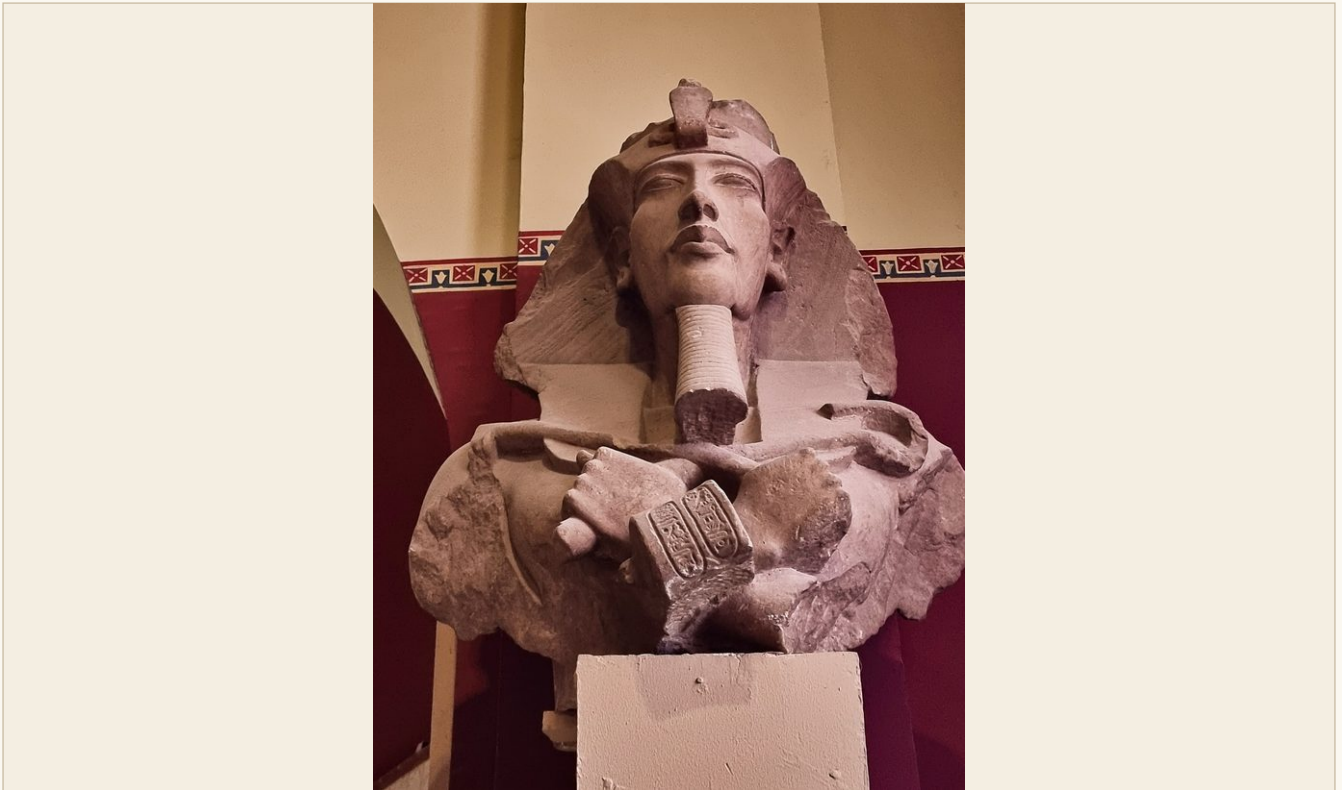
ON THE THRONE

Punt

THE GREAT TRADING VOYAGE

3 terraces

AT DEIR EL-BAHARI



A colossal statue of Amenhotep IV from his temple at Karnak, carved before he moved the court to Amarna and took the name Akhenaten. The elongated face and heavy hips are the signature of the new style.

The Heretic and the Queen

One king tried to replace the gods of Egypt with a single disc of light. It lasted about seventeen years.

Amenhotep IV changed his name to Akhenaten, closed the temples of Amun, and moved the court to a virgin site in the desert that he called Akhetaten — the Horizon of the Aten. The Aten was the sun's disc itself, shown as a circle with rays ending in small hands, and its only authorised interpreter was the king.

Art changed with the theology. The rigid ideal of earlier reigns gave way to elongated skulls, heavy hips and slack bellies, and to domestic scenes with no precedent: the royal couple with daughters on their laps, eating, kissing, mourning a dead child.

The archive found at the site — the Amarna letters,

written in Akkadian on clay — shows the other side of the experiment. Vassals in Canaan and Syria write again and again for troops that do not come while Egypt's northern position quietly erodes.

Within a few years of his death the court was back at Thebes, the old gods were restored, and Akhenaten had been struck from the official king lists as 'the enemy'. He survived only because his abandoned capital was never built over — and because a German expedition opened a sculptor's studio there in 1912 and found his wife's face on a shelf.

17 years

OF THE ATEN

1912

NEFERTITI BUST FOUND

382

AMARNA LETTERS KNOWN



The gold funerary mask of Tutankhamun, inlaid with lapis lazuli, carnelian and coloured glass, on display in Cairo.

The Boy King

He was a minor pharaoh who died before he was twenty. He matters because of what did not happen to his tomb.

Tutankhaten came to the throne as a child in the wreckage of his father's revolution. Under the guidance of the old court he changed his name to Tutankhamun, restored the temples of Amun and left a stela describing the country he had inherited as one whose gods had turned their backs on it.

He ruled for about nine years and died around the age of nineteen. Examination of the body and of DNA from related mummies points to a frail young man — a club foot, malaria, a badly broken leg — rather than the murder plot of popular legend, though the evidence remains argued over.

His burial was hurried. The tomb, KV62, is small and oddly proportioned for a king, its walls painted in haste. That modesty saved it: within a couple of generations the entrance was buried under the spoil heaps of a grander tomb next door and the robbers who emptied every other royal burial in the valley never found it.

So the only pharaoh's grave to survive nearly intact belongs to the one nobody thought important — 5,398 objects, from chariots and folding beds to a mask of eleven kilograms of gold. What the world pictures when it pictures Egypt is largely the contents of a second-rank funeral.

~19

AGE AT DEATH

5,398

OBJECTS IN THE TOMB

10.2 kg

GOLD IN THE MASK



The Great Temple at Abu Simbel in an early photograph from the Museo Egizio archive, before the facade was cut up and moved. Each seated colossus is about twenty metres high.

The Builder and the Battle

Ramesses II reigned for sixty-six years, fought the ancient world's most famous draw, and then signed the first peace treaty we can still read.

In 1274 BC, at Kadesh on the Orontes, Ramesses walked into a Hittite ambush with his army strung out on the march. By his own account, carved across half the temples of Egypt, he rallied alone and broke the enemy. The Hittite records claim the field. Modern reading of both makes it a bloody stalemate that left the frontier roughly where it started.

What followed is the more remarkable document. About sixteen years later Egypt and Hatti agreed terms — mutual defence, non-aggression, the return of fugitives — and both copies survive, one in Egyptian on a temple wall at Karnak,

one in Akkadian on clay from the Hittite capital. It is the earliest international peace treaty whose text we have from both sides. A replica hangs at the United Nations.

The rest of the reign was construction on an industrial scale: the Ramesseum, additions at Karnak and Luxor, a new Delta capital, and the two rock-cut temples at Abu Simbel, aligned so that twice a year the rising sun reaches the statues in the innermost sanctuary.

Those temples were sawn into more than a thousand blocks in the 1960s and rebuilt sixty-five metres higher to keep them above the rising water of the Aswan reservoir.

66 years

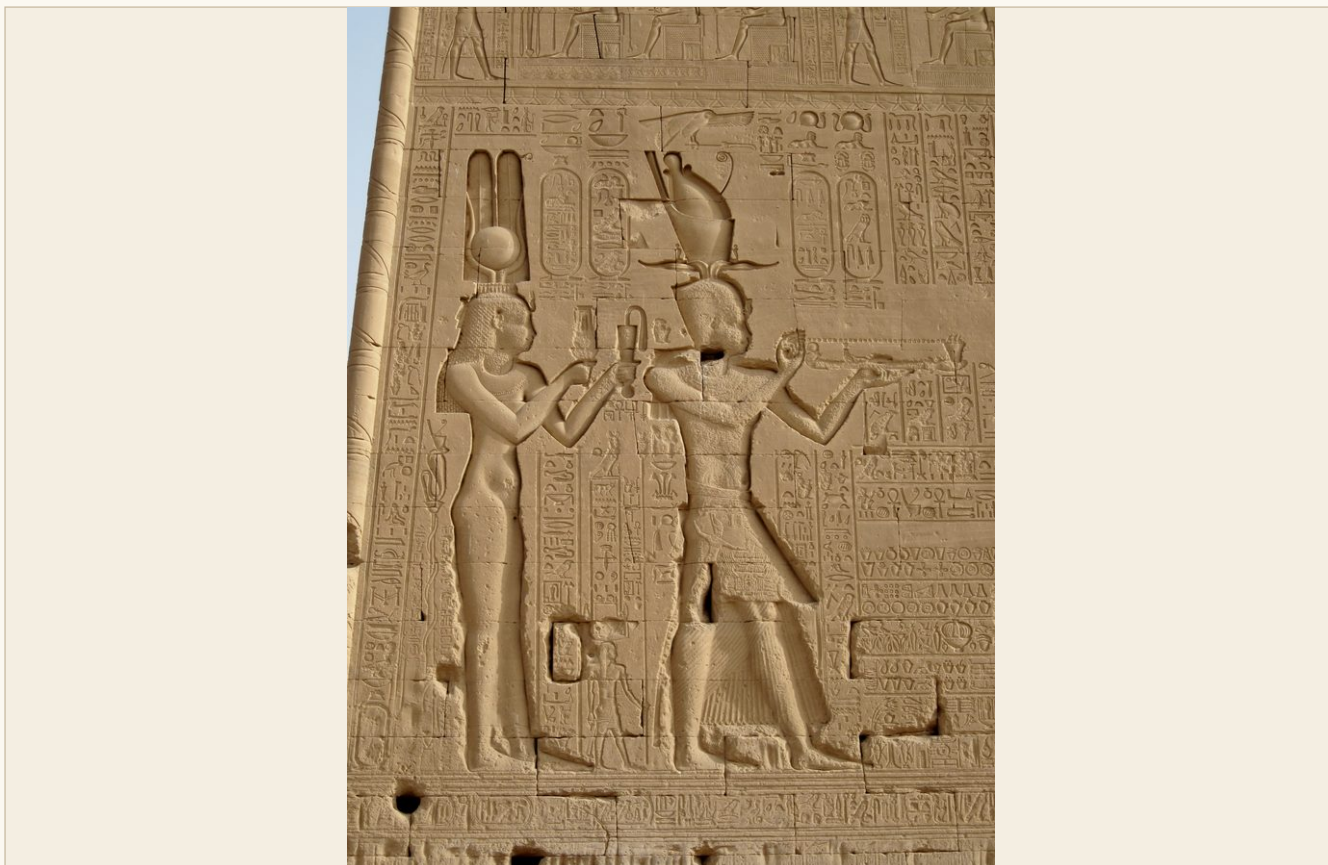
ON THE THRONE

1274 BC

THE BATTLE OF KADESH

1,036

BLOCKS ABU SIMBEL WAS CUT INTO



Cleopatra VII and her son Caesarion, carved on the south-west exterior wall of the temple of Hathor at Dendera — one of the few images of her made in Egypt, in Egyptian style.

The Last Pharaoh

She was Greek, she was the first of her dynasty to bother learning Egyptian, and she was the last person to rule Egypt as an independent state for nearly two thousand years.

Alexander took Egypt from the Persians in 332 BC; on his death his general Ptolemy kept it. For three centuries the Ptolemies ruled from Alexandria as pharaohs on temple walls and Macedonian kings everywhere else, speaking Greek, marrying their siblings and funding the Library.

Cleopatra VII inherited a kingdom that was already, in practice, a Roman client. Her response was to attach herself to whichever Roman was winning — Julius Caesar, and after his murder Mark Antony — and to trade Egypt's grain and money for a share of the outcome.

It failed at Actium in 31 BC. Antony and Cleopatra lost the fleet, then Alexandria, then their lives; her son by Caesar was killed on Octavian's orders. Egypt became not a province like other provinces but the personal estate of the emperor, and its wheat fed Rome.

The old religion outlasted the last pharaoh by four centuries. The final dated hieroglyphic inscription was cut at Philae in AD 394, and the last demotic a generation later. The language itself did not die: written in Greek letters, it became Coptic, and is still sung in Egyptian churches.

332 BC

ALEXANDER ARRIVES

31 BC

THE BATTLE OF ACTIUM

AD 394

LAST HIEROGLYPHS CUT



From the Book of the Dead of Hunefer, c. 1275 BC: the heart of the dead man is weighed against the feather of truth while Thoth records the verdict.

Words of the God

For three and a half thousand years Egypt wrote everything down. Then, for fourteen hundred, nobody could read it.

Hieroglyphs are not picture-writing in the sense usually meant. The signs work as sounds, as whole words, and as silent markers that tell you which kind of word you are looking at — a system flexible enough to handle poetry, contracts, medical texts and shopping lists.

Three scripts ran in parallel: monumental hieroglyphs for stone, cursive hieratic for papyrus, and from about 650 BC the faster demotic for daily business. When Egypt turned Christian and then Muslim the scripts fell out of use, and the meaning was lost so thoroughly that medieval scholars read the signs as mystical symbols.

The key came out of the ground at Rosetta in 1799

during Napoleon's occupation: one decree, three scripts, the Greek version readable. Jean-François Champollion announced the decipherment in 1822, working from the Rosetta Stone and from Coptic, the descendant language still in liturgical use.

What the texts gave back was an interior life. The Book of the Dead is a working manual for getting through the underworld, and its central scene is a courtroom: the heart weighed against the feather of Maat, order and truth. Balance, and you pass. Fail, and the monster waiting beside the scales eats you, and you simply stop existing.

c. 3200 BC

WRITING BEGINS

1799

ROSETTA STONE FOUND

1822

CHAMPOLLION READS IT

II

THE MODERN NATION

1805 – 2025

*A viceroy, a canal, a revolution, two wars and a museum: how the
country on top of the ruins made itself.*



Muhammad Ali Pasha, painted by Auguste Couder in 1841. An Ottoman officer from Kavala, he founded the dynasty that ruled Egypt until 1952.

The Pasha Who Made a State

Napoleon's invasion lasted three years and changed nothing. The Albanian sergeant who filled the vacuum afterwards changed everything.

The French occupation of 1798–1801 broke the old order in Egypt without replacing it. Into the wreckage stepped Muhammad Ali, commander of an Albanian contingent in the Ottoman force sent to restore order, who by 1805 had manoeuvred the notables of Cairo into naming him governor. In 1811 he removed the last of his rivals by inviting the Mamluk beys to a banquet in the Citadel and having them shot on the way out.

What he built afterwards was recognisably a modern state, assembled with a ruthlessness that its subjects paid for. Peasants were conscripted into a standing army drilled on the French model. Long-staple cotton was introduced

and the whole crop bought and sold by the government at prices it set. Canals were dug, a barrage begun, schools of medicine and engineering opened, and a state press at Bulaq printed textbooks in Arabic.

He very nearly took the Ottoman Empire with it. His armies held Syria and were marching on Istanbul when the European powers intervened in 1840 and forced him back — in exchange for hereditary rule of Egypt for his family.

That bargain shaped the next century: an Egypt nominally Ottoman, practically independent, and increasingly financed by European banks.

1805

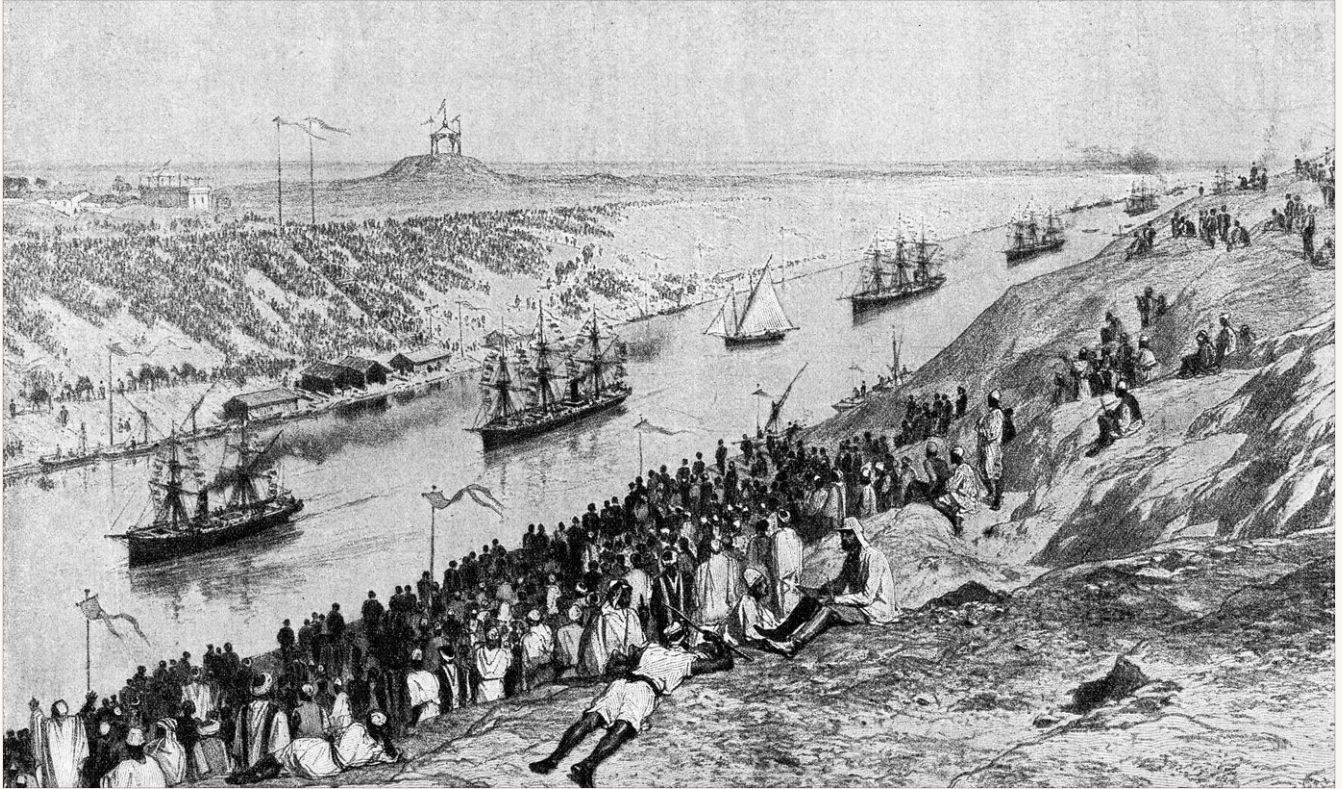
SEIZES POWER

1811

THE CITADEL MASSACRE

147 years

HIS DYNASTY LASTED



The inauguration of the Suez Canal, 17 November 1869. A procession of ships led by the French imperial yacht sailed from Port Said to Ismailia.

A Ditch Between Two Seas

The canal cut 7,000 kilometres off the voyage from London to Bombay. It also cost Egypt its independence.

Ferdinand de Lesseps got his concession from the viceroy Said in 1854 and broke ground in 1859. The first years of digging were done by *corvée* — forced labour levied from the villages, tens of thousands of men at a time, working the sand by hand. Deaths ran high enough that international pressure eventually pushed the company towards machines.

The opening on 17 November 1869 was staged as a global event: the Empress Eugénie at the head of the procession, guests shipped in from every European capital, an opera house built in Cairo for the occasion. Verdi's *Aida*, commissioned around it, arrived late and premiered there in 1871.

Egypt had borrowed enormously for the canal and for the modernisation around it, on terms that were punitive from the start. By 1875 the khedive Ismail was insolvent and sold Egypt's shares in the canal company to the British government. Debt commissioners followed, then a nationalist revolt, then in 1882 a British fleet at Alexandria and an occupation that would last, in one form or another, for seventy-four years.

The waterway itself did exactly what was promised. Roughly a tenth of world seaborne trade still passes through it.

164 km

ORIGINAL LENGTH

1875

SHARES SOLD TO BRITAIN

~10%

OF WORLD TRADE TODAY



Howard Carter and his assistant Arthur Callender examining objects from the tomb, photographed by Harry Burton during the clearance, around 1924.

Wonderful Things

Egypt got its nominal independence and its most famous tomb in the same year, and the two facts turned out to be connected.

By 1922 Howard Carter had been digging in the Valley of the Kings for years with nothing to show, and his patron Lord Carnarvon had agreed to fund one final season. On 4 November a water boy clearing sand near the tomb of Ramesses VI uncovered a cut step. Sixteen steps and a sealed door later, on 26 November, Carter made a hole, held a candle to it, and was asked whether he could see anything. ‘Yes,’ he said. ‘Wonderful things.’

Clearing the four small rooms took ten years and a discipline unusual for the period: every object was photographed in place by Harry Burton, catalogued, and conserved before it moved.

The find landed in the middle of a political argument. Britain had declared Egypt formally independent on 28 February 1922 while keeping control of defence, foreign policy and the Sudan. Carnarvon’s attempt to sell exclusive coverage to *The Times*, and the assumption that the finds would be split with London, ran straight into a nationalist press that treated the tomb as Egyptian property.

It stayed. The whole collection remained in Egypt, and a generation of Egyptian politicians and artists took up the pharaonic past as national inheritance rather than tourist curiosity.

4 Nov 1922

THE STEP FOUND

10 years

TO CLEAR THE TOMB

28 Feb 1922

NOMINAL INDEPENDENCE



The Free Officers welcomed by crowds in Cairo in the months after the coup. Gamal Abdel Nasser is third from the left in the car.

The Officers

A conspiracy of junior officers took Cairo in a night, and the monarchy was on a boat within three days.

The defeat of 1948 in Palestine, an economy still run for the benefit of foreign bondholders and a court widely seen as a British appendage produced, among mid-ranking officers, the Free Officers movement. On the night of 22–23 July 1952 they seized army headquarters, the broadcasting station and the telephone exchange, and announced the change over the radio at dawn.

King Farouk abdicated on 26 July and sailed from Alexandria on the royal yacht. There was almost no bloodshed. General Muhammad Naguib, senior and respectable, was given the front of the movement; Gamal Abdel Nasser, who had built it, stayed behind him for two

years.

The first substantive act was land reform in September 1952, capping individual holdings at two hundred feddans and breaking the political power of the great estates. The monarchy was abolished and a republic declared on 18 June 1953.

By 1954 the two men at the top had diverged — Naguib favouring a return to parliamentary politics, Nasser and the Revolutionary Command Council against it. Nasser won, Naguib was placed under house arrest, and Egypt acquired the pattern of rule by an officer-president that it has broken only briefly since.

23 July 1952

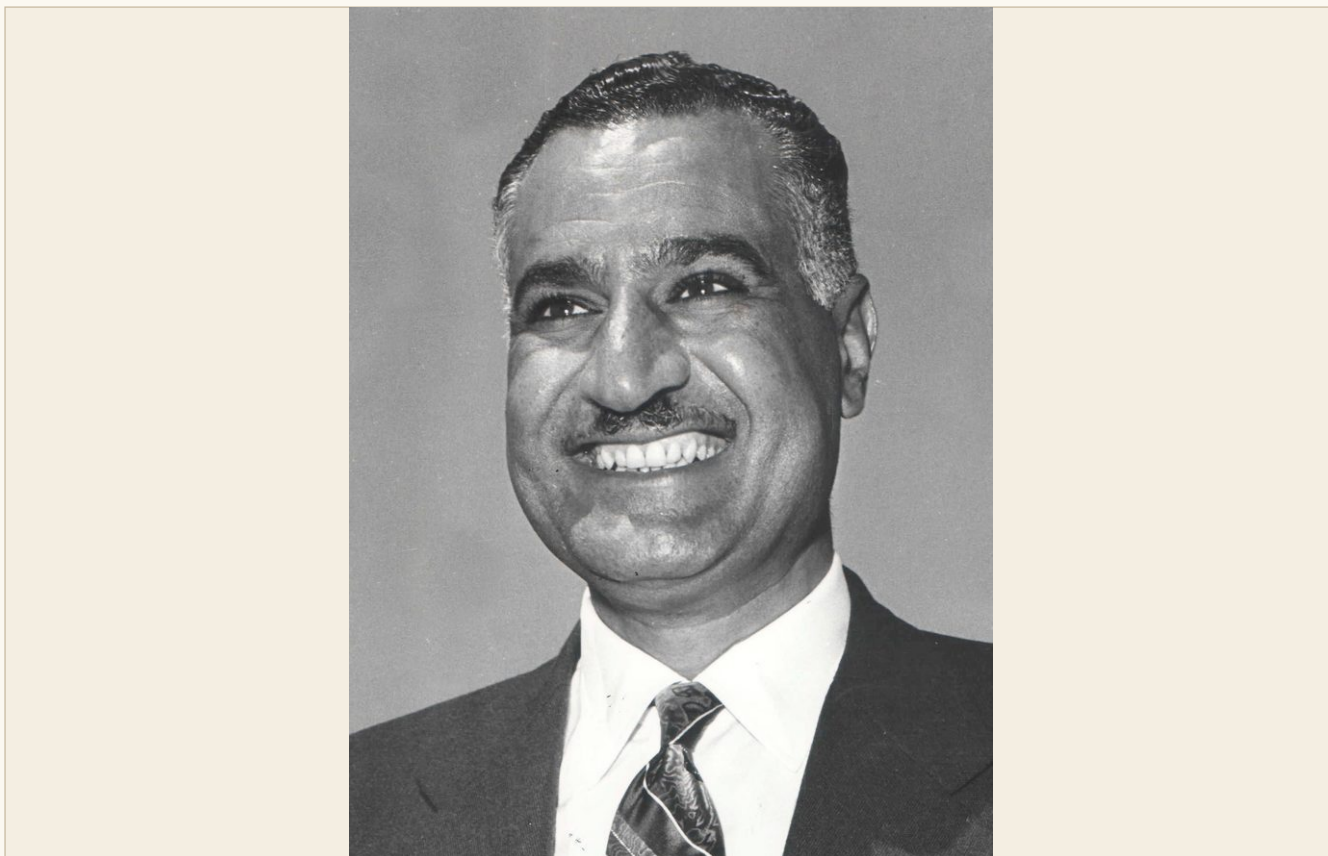
THE COUP

26 July

FAROUK ABDICATES

18 June 1953

REPUBLIC DECLARED



Gamal Abdel Nasser in 1962. Nationalising the Suez Canal Company made him, for a decade, the most popular politician in the Arab world.

Nasser

He lost the battle for the canal and won the argument — which set the pattern, good and bad, for everything that followed.

When Washington and London withdrew their offer to finance the Aswan High Dam, Nasser answered on 26 July 1956 with a speech in Alexandria announcing the nationalisation of the Suez Canal Company. Its revenues, he said, would build the dam instead.

Britain and France, with Israel, invaded in October under a pretext agreed in advance. Militarily it worked; politically it collapsed. The United States, unwilling to be associated with a colonial adventure, applied financial pressure on the pound; the Soviet Union threatened worse. The invaders withdrew, and a defeat in the field became the

founding victory of Arab nationalism.

For ten years Nasser was the voice of that project — non-alignment, Arab unity, land reform, free schooling and a vast public sector. Egypt and Syria briefly merged as the United Arab Republic between 1958 and 1961. Radio carried his speeches across every border in the region.

It ended in six days in June 1967, when Israel destroyed the Egyptian air force on the ground and took the whole of Sinai. Nasser offered to resign, was kept in place by crowds in the street, and died of a heart attack in September 1970 at fifty-two. Millions followed the coffin.

26 July 1956

THE CANAL NATIONALISED

1958-61

THE UNITED ARAB REPUBLIC

1967

SINAI LOST IN SIX DAYS



The Aswan High Dam. Behind it, Lake Nasser stretches more than five hundred kilometres upstream and across the Sudanese border.

The Dam

Egypt ended the annual flood that had made it. The bargain was electricity and certainty, paid for in silt, salt and displaced villages.

The High Dam is a rockfill embankment 111 metres high and nearly four kilometres long, built between 1960 and 1970 with Soviet money and engineers after the Western offer was withdrawn. Behind it lies Lake Nasser, one of the largest artificial lakes in the world.

The gains were real and immediate. The flood no longer arrived as a gamble; water could be released on demand, allowing two or three crops a year instead of one. The turbines at one point supplied about half the country's electricity. When drought struck the Sahel in the 1980s, Egypt drew on the reservoir and avoided famine.

The costs are structural. The silt that renewed the fields for five thousand years now settles behind the dam, so

Egyptian farming runs on imported fertiliser and the Delta coastline, no longer fed with sediment, is eroding into the sea. Salinity has risen. Waterborne disease spread with year-round irrigation.

And the reservoir drowned Nubia. More than a hundred thousand Nubians were moved to new settlements far from the river, and their villages, cemeteries and history went under the water. The temples were saved — Abu Simbel and Philae were cut apart and rebuilt on higher ground in a UNESCO campaign that invented modern international heritage rescue. The people were not offered the same engineering.

111 m

DAM HEIGHT

5,250 km²

LAKE NASSER

100,000+

NUBIANS DISPLACED



Egyptian forces crossing the Suez Canal on pontoon bridges in the opening hours of the October War.

The Crossing

High-pressure water hoses opened the Israeli sand wall in a few hours. That engineering trick is the reason there was a peace treaty six years later.

The Bar-Lev Line was a rampart of sand along the east bank of the canal, high enough that any assault would have to be preceded by days of visible engineering work. Egyptian planners solved it with fire pumps: jets of canal water cut breaches through the sand in hours rather than days.

At two in the afternoon on 6 October 1973 — Yom Kippur, and during Ramadan — artillery opened and the first waves went across in rubber boats. Within about a day some 80,000 troops were on the east bank, under an umbrella of Soviet surface-to-air missiles that kept the Israeli air force at a distance and gave the infantry anti-tank

missiles that surprised the armour sent against them.

The war did not stay won. When Egyptian forces advanced beyond the missile cover in mid October they were badly mauled, and an Israeli counter-crossing at the Deversoir gap encircled the Third Army on the west bank before the ceasefire of 25 October.

The military ledger was ambiguous; the political one was not. Egypt had planned and executed a modern combined-arms operation, and the assumption that the 1967 lines were permanent was broken. Sadat had the standing at home to do what came next.

14:05

H-HOUR, 6 OCTOBER

~80,000

TROOPS ACROSS IN A DAY

25 Oct

CEASEFIRE



Anwar Sadat, Jimmy Carter and Menachem Begin during the negotiations at Camp David in September 1978.

The Handshake

Sadat flew to Jerusalem, spoke to the Knesset, got Sinai back — and was shot on the anniversary of his own war.

In November 1977 Sadat announced that he would go to Israel in person, and did: a plane into Ben Gurion airport, a speech to the Knesset, an audience of astonished Arab governments. It broke a taboo that had held for thirty years.

The negotiations that followed nearly failed. Jimmy Carter kept Sadat and Menachem Begin at Camp David for thirteen days in September 1978, shuttling between cabins because the two men could barely be in a room together, and produced two framework agreements signed on 17 September. The peace treaty followed on 26 March 1979 — the first between Israel and an Arab state.

Egypt recovered the whole of Sinai, completed by 1982. Sadat and Begin shared the Nobel Peace Prize. The second framework, on Palestinian autonomy, was never implemented, and that omission defined the reaction: Egypt was expelled from the Arab League and the League's headquarters moved out of Cairo for a decade.

On 6 October 1981, at the parade marking the crossing, soldiers from an Islamist cell in the army opened fire on the reviewing stand and killed him. His vice-president, Hosni Mubarak, took over and stayed for thirty years.

13 days

AT CAMP DAVID

26 Mar 1979

TREATY SIGNED

1982

SINAI FULLY RETURNED



Tahrir Square, central Cairo, filled with demonstrators in February 2011 during the final week of the protests against Hosni Mubarak.

Eighteen Days

A protest called for Police Day became the largest gathering in modern Egyptian history — and then the hard part began.

The call went out for 25 January 2011, the national holiday honouring the police, and the turnout was far beyond what the organisers expected. Within days Tahrir Square was permanently occupied, with field clinics, checkpoints run by volunteers and nightly crowds in the hundreds of thousands.

The government cut the country off the internet on 28 January, which did not work: protests spread to Alexandria, Suez and the Delta. On 2 February riders on horses and camels charged the square in what became known as the Battle of the Camel. The army, deployed but declining to fire on the crowds, was the decisive variable.

On 11 February, after eighteen days, the vice-president

announced that Hosni Mubarak had stepped down after thirty years, and power passed to the Supreme Council of the Armed Forces.

What followed satisfied few of the people in the square. A parliamentary election, then Mohamed Morsi of the Muslim Brotherhood elected president in 2012; mass protests against him a year later; his removal by the military in July 2013 and a violent dispersal of the sit-ins that followed; and from 2014 the presidency of Abdel Fattah el-Sisi under a new constitution. The eighteen days remain the reference point everyone in the argument still uses.

25 Jan 2011

FIRST DAY

18 days

TO MUBARAK'S RESIGNATION

30 years

HE HAD RULED



The pyramids seen from inside the Grand Egyptian Museum, which opened in full on 1 November 2025.

The House of the Pharaohs

Twenty years, half a million square metres and a billion dollars later, Tutankhamun's burial is shown whole for the first time since it was buried.

The Grand Egyptian Museum sits on the desert edge at Giza with the pyramids framed through the glass of its north wall. The design, chosen in an international competition won by the Dublin practice Heneghan Peng, folds the building into the escarpment so that the monuments outside remain the tallest thing in view.

A colossus of Ramesses II stands in the atrium, moved across Cairo from the railway square where it had stood for half a century. From there a grand staircase climbs six storeys past royal statuary towards a window on the plateau — a walk arranged so that the visitor arrives at the real pyramids after four thousand years of preparation.

The centrepiece is the Tutankhamun collection, all of it: more than five thousand objects from KV62 displayed together for the first time since Carter's team lifted them out. The old Egyptian Museum in Tahrir, opened in 1902 and long past capacity, keeps its own collection and hands over the crowds.

It is a fitting place to stop. The country that has spent two centuries excavating, arguing over and repatriating its own past has built the largest museum in the world devoted to a single civilisation — within sight of the tomb that started it.

~500,000 m²

SITE AREA

1 Nov 2025

FULL OPENING

5,000+

TUTANKHAMUN OBJECTS

PHOTOGRAPH CREDITS

Every photograph in this book comes from Wikimedia Commons and is used under the licence shown. Public-domain and CC0 images carry no conditions; CC BY and CC BY-SA images require the attribution printed here, and CC BY-SA additionally requires that any adapted version be shared under the same terms.

Cover

Pyramids of the Giza Necropolis.jpg — KennyOMG — CC BY-SA 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

Part I opener

Luxor, Egypt, Karnak, Great Hypostyle Hall, Columns.jpg — Vyacheslav Argenberg — CC BY 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

Part II opener

Cairo skyline, Nile River, Egypt.jpg — Vyacheslav Argenberg — CC BY 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Gift of the River

Felucca at Kom Ombo on the River Nile - panoramio.jpg — David Broad — CC BY 3.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

Two Lands, One Crown

Narmer Palette smiting side.jpg — unknown author — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

The First Pyramid

Pyramid of Djoser 2010.jpg — Wknight94 — CC BY-SA 3.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Great Pyramid

Great Pyramid (Pyramid of Cheops Khufu), Giza, GG, EGY (40936205113).jpg — Warren LeMay from Chicago, IL, United States — CC0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Woman Who Was King

Templo funerario de Hatshepsut, Valle de las Reyes, Luxor, Egipto, 2022-04-03, DD 118.jpg — Diego Delso — CC BY-SA 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Heretic and the Queen

Colossal Statue of Amenhotep IV from Karnak, 1356-1350 BCE (1).jpg — Prof. Mortel — CC BY 2.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Boy King

Mask of Tutankhamun in 2025.jpg — Dawid Wdowczyk — CC BY 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Builder and the Battle

Nubia, Temples of Abu Simbel, Pictures, photo 3 of 7 - Archivio fotografico Museo Egizio, Turin INV25 010.jpg — unknown author — CC0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Last Pharaoh

Dendera Tempel 14.JPG — Olaf Tausch — CC BY 3.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

Words of the God

Book of the Dead of Hunefer sheet 3.jpg — Hunefer — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

The Pasha Who Made a State

ModernEgypt, Muhammad Ali by Auguste Couder, BAP 17996.jpg — unknown author — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

A Ditch Between Two Seas

Открытие Суэцкого канала, 1869.jpg — Сканирование: Владимир Васильев — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

Wonderful Things

Howard Carter and Arthur Callender in Tutankhamun's tomb.jpg — Harry Burton — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

The Officers

1953 Egypt revolution celebrations.jpg — unknown author — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

Nasser

Gamal Abdel Nasser Portrait 1962 (3x4 cropped).jpg — Stevan Kragujević — CC BY-SA 3.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Dam

Aswan Dam 21-2-08.jpg — Sigurd Gartmann — CC BY-SA 2.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The Crossing

Egyptians Crossing Suez Canal.jpg — CIA — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

The Handshake

Begin, Carter and Sadat at Camp David 1978.jpg — Fitz-Patrick, Bill, photographer — Public domain — via Wikimedia Commons

Eighteen Days

Tahrir Square during 8 February 2011.jpg — Mona — CC BY 2.0 — via Wikimedia Commons

The House of the Pharaohs

View of Pyramids of Giza from Grand Egyptian Museum.jpg — Caoimheen3 — CC BY-SA 4.0 — via Wikimedia Commons